

EVEN GANDHI'S PHOTOS HAVE BEEN LISTED FOR AUCTION



and the National Gandhi Museum in Delhi. The two institutions had acquired the originals many decades ago from individual owners, copied them and then returned them.

Ruhe was evasive when cornered by journalists on one of his recent trips to Gujarat. "You should not question my intentions but that of those who have parted with this material. I am a facilitator and not a dealer. Fifty per cent of the money that comes from the sale of these images and articles goes to their owners and remaining 50 per cent to the foundation I run in Germany and which does education research projects on Gandhi. Gandhi said institu-

Gandhi collection to him in 2001 for \$5.50 million (Rs 24.75 crore).

In the other hand, Upen says Ruhe paid his father Rs 25,000 for some of the pictures Ruhe used in a book he wrote on Gandhi. Says Upen: "Ruhe's claim that he has got the originals of my father's image collection is wrong since he just has the copies. But I respect Ruhe. He not only paid money to my father when he needed it but also offered financial help after his death. Many Gandhians made use of my father's pictures without bothering to pay." Ruhe also claims that technically he has done a much better job of restoring many of the Gandhi pictures than many institu-

Peter Ruhe had offered to sell his entire Gandhi collection to me in 2001 for \$5.5 million.

TUSHAR GANDHI, *The Mahatma's grandson*



Even after 60 years we haven't learnt to protect our heritage. Today it's Gandhi. Tomorrow it could be Ambedkar or Savarkar.

TRIDIP SUHRUD, *Member, Sabarmati Ashram Trust*



Gandhian legacy, owns 248 art items, 2,947 letters, 1,583 pictures, 31 cartoons, 407 documents and 513 publications.

But what came as a shocker early this year was a letter marked secret which Ruhe addressed to Tridip Suhrud, a member of one of the committees of the Sabarmati Ashram Trust in Ahmedabad, offering to sell his entire collection of Gandhian articles, at a discounted price of around Rs 5.50 crore. In that letter, Ruhe claims that his personal collection has been acquired over the past 24 years and added that he wishes to sell the original items to someone who truly appreciates Mahatma Gandhi. Interestingly, the copies of most of the material he has are with the Sabarmati Ashram in Ahmedabad

tions should be self-sufficient and I am only trying to follow him," Ruhe told INDIA TODAY.

At the New York auction, Otis produced a letter of consent from Gita Mehta, the adopted daughter of Abha (the sole custodian of the four articles sold at the auction before she died in 2001; Mehta inherited them thereafter). Mehta kept silent when the controversy flared at the time of auction but later said that she had not issued a consent letter for auction but a letter permitting their exhibition.

Gandhi's Mumbai-based grandson Tushar Gandhi is now thinking of challenging Ruhe's claims in an international court. He has known Ruhe over the past two decades. Tushar says Ruhe offered to sell his entire

tions in India might have done.

Indeed, it shows how sloppily India preserves its heritage. Only recently, Gandhian scholar Rizwan Kadri collected from a Ahmedabad Sunday market, 275 letters addressed by three prominent Gandhians, Kaka Kalelkar, Sardar Patel's daughter Maniben Patel and Morarji Desai, to the then trustee of Navjivan Trust, Jivabhai Desai. The original letters, some of which are very important for their historical content were apparently disposed of as waste paper by the Navjivan Trust—the body to whom Gandhiji had willed the copyright of his letters and publications. The question of the legacy of the Mahatma always provokes a heated debate, and so has the question of his physical and pictorial legacy. ■